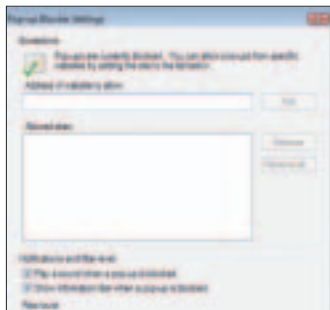


ance and function to traditional multi-socket extension leads but sometimes also include sockets for a telephone line and network cable to protect additional hardware against the threat of power surges. Surge protectors often include an equipment warranty, so should computer hardware become damaged as a result of a power surge, and the surge protector was in use, it is possible to claim compensation for any loss.



Allow certain pop-ups from particular websites in IE7

be walking on carpet with a deep pile, and this charge can be all too easily discharged into a hardware component you are about to install when you reach inside the computer case.

Before attempting any hardware operations, there are two steps that can be taken to avoid damaging your computer in this way. First, the vast majority of computer hardware is supplied in antistatic bags, and components should always be stored in these until they are needed and only removed at the last moment.

Second, to prevent static from discharging once you are inside the computer case, there are two possible methods. The first is to use an antistatic wristband. This strap needs to be worn around the wrist and the other end earthed by connecting it to exposed metal — for example, the metal of a radiator or of the computer case itself, providing the computer is plugged in but switched off. Such wristbands offer ongoing protection from the danger of static, but a free alternative is to simply touch



A firewall is in place to protect against malware threats

some earthed metal with your hand and continue doing so while you are working inside your computer.

The inevitable

Unfortunately, no matter how thorough you are with your disaster avoidance strategy, there will still be the occasional, seemingly random, problem that crops up. As such, you need to be not only vigilant and security-conscious in your computer use, but also prepared for the worst.

Hardware failure can all too easily lead to the loss of personal files, so it is extremely important to have a backup strategy in place — and perhaps the best investment any computer owner can make is in a USB hard disk. This could be used to provide extra storage, but it also acts as a relatively cheap and reusable backup medium — more practical and easier to use than recordable CD and DVDs.

Backing up your valuable data, optimising your PC and remaining vigilant when it comes to security — you'll find that keeping one step ahead of potential pitfalls and preventing problems before they happen are themes that will recur throughout this magazine. But, of course, it's not always possible to predict what's going to happen with the intricate and sensitive machine sitting on your desktop. And, with that in mind, you'll also find that this Ultimate Guide will also arm you with all the knowledge you need to get yourself out of a tight situation and provide you with valuable advice on how to recover should the worst come to the worst.



Windows Vista's web browser, IE7, helps protect your computer against potential threats